basis of UN resolutions and talks and negotiations,' he said.[84] The Mujahideen were wary of getting caught in the India-Pakistan rivalry. Moreover, given the internal rifts within the Mujahideen, good relations with India were seen as an insurance against Pakistan's micromanagement of their internal affairs.

Thus, New Delhi's opening up to the Mujahideen, was not simply about optics and signaling good-faith to a rising political dispensation in a neighbouring country. It was loaded with strategic intent. India did not want Rawalpindi to dictate the terms of peace in a post-Najibullah Afghanistan. More than direct links between the Mujahideen and Kashmiri militants, India fretted over the boost that the Mujahideen's rise would give to Pakistan in fomenting militancy in Kashmir. Dialogue with different Mujahideen factions was necessary to strike such a strategic balance. Rabbani, Massoud, and Mojadeddi proved to be perfect candidates to open such channels. They had worked closely with Pakistan but reflected independent agency. Hekmatyar's case was more complicated. A Pashtun from Kunduz, Hekmatyar represented urban Islamists that were radicalised at the Kabul University in the late-1960s. Without any geographical base like Massoud and Rabbani (who were rooted in the Panjshir Valley) Hekmatyar thrived on external support. Though Hekmatyar's relationship with Pakistan was mainly transactional in nature, he was dependent on Rawalpindi and amenable to accepting Pakistan's demands for training Kashmiri militants. Pakistan's inability to manage these intra-Mujahideen differences became evident in the fact that the Peshawar accord of 24 April 1992, facilitated by Pakistan's PM Nawaz Sharif with Saudi blessing, blew up in its face in less than a week, as Afghanistan descended into civil war. In May 1992 Mojaddedi raked up the Durand Line issue and, much like Najibullah and most previous Afghan leaders, rejected it as an international border.[85]

Internal rifts within the Mujahideen had been evident since the beginning of the Soviet intervention. Aware of these differences, and despite Rajiv's official policy of dealing only with Najibullah, the R&AW and the MEA had developed covert contacts with the Mujahideen by late 1980s. These links were not just limited to the perceived anti-Pakistan elements. India opened covert channels with Mojadeddi, Rabbani, Sayyaf, Massoud, Dostum, as well as Hekmatyar. A currently serving top MEA official, 'L', who was posted in Iran from 1988 to